



BUILDING YOUR AV STRATEGY ACROSS THE ENTIRE EVENT LIFECYCLE.

AV365

What a good AV partner is doing at every stage of your event, and why the most expensive decisions get made before anyone asks for a price.

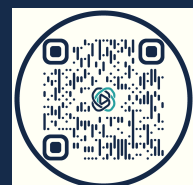
WRITTEN FOR

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SCAN TO CONNECT

AV is how you communicate with your attendees. Everything they see, hear, and remember runs through it. Which makes it strange that AV is usually the last vendor in the room.

By the time most planners send an AV request for proposal, the venue is signed, the agenda is drafted, and the room block is set. Those three documents have already decided a large share of what AV will cost and how well it can work. Not because anyone made a bad call, but because nobody was thinking about load-in paths, exclusivity clauses, or 24-hour holds at the moment those calls got made.

I started in this industry in the early '90s. Back then, if the microphones worked and the projector didn't topple over, you could call the meeting a success. That is not the job anymore. You are competing for sponsors, exhibitors, and attendees, on a tighter budget and a shorter clock, and a conference now has to deliver an experience, not just information.

There are four stages in the life of an event: site selection, planning, execution, and review. Here is what should be happening in each one.

WHERE IT BEGINS

You cannot get AV involved too early

That is not a sales line, it is a sequencing fact. Your AV partner is the only vendor whose cost is driven almost entirely by decisions other people make: which building you pick, how the rooms are held, when the doors open, and how fast the flip has to happen.

Bring them in while those are still questions and they can help you shape the answers. Bring them in afterward and all they can do is price what you already committed to.

Use what follows as a checklist for your own process. Or read it, decide you already have enough on your plate, and hand it to a partner you trust. Either way these items get decided. The only question is whether anyone decided them on purpose.

STAGE ONE

Site selection

Your venue contract is an AV document. It just isn't written like one.

A trusted AV partner should read that contract before you sign it, look at the space from a technical and logistical perspective, and help you negotiate. They will find things that are

invisible on a floor plan and expensive to discover in month ten. Here is what the two of you should be working through while you still have more than one building to choose from.

- **Exclusivity.** Are any areas off-limits to an outside AV partner? Rigging is almost always handled by the in-house rigging vendor, and that one is a legitimate safety issue. Occasionally the in-house company is exclusive in the ballroom or the meeting rooms. Know every restriction before you sign, not after.
- **Fees.** The most diligent planners confirm that their AV partner is allowed to work in the building, and then never establish what it will cost them to do it. Understand and negotiate those fees up front. That doesn't mean you won't use the in-house company. It keeps your options open, and it usually lowers the price of whichever option you choose.
- **Load-in and load-out rules.** Some cities prohibit overnight loading. Some require a permit before you block a lane. Ask what applies to this building, in this city, and what it does to your schedule.
- **The dock.** Is there one, or are you unloading at street level? Is it truck height? Does the truck have to be scheduled through security? Are there hours when the dock belongs to the hotel's own deliveries?
- **The path.** How far is it from the dock to the meeting space, and is it wide and clear? Is a freight elevator involved, how big is it, and does it need an operator? Answers to these questions move an AV budget more than most planners expect.
- **Room size.** Capacity charts never include the footprint of staging, screens, or front of house. Confirm that every general session, breakout, and meal room still holds your attendees once the AV is in it.
- **Sleeping rooms.** When you are negotiating complimentary or staff-rate rooms, count your AV team in the block.

Then there is possession, the item planners most often leave to chance.

When you should take possession of the room	
General session	A full day before doors, sometimes more
Breakout rooms	The afternoon or evening before
Meal and reception rooms	Before the flip, not during it
Every contracted room	24-hour hold, start to finish

A 24-hour hold means that once you take a room, you keep it, start to finish.

Without that hold, you can find yourself striking a room for a late-night gala and rebuilding it before breakfast. And setting a room the same morning it goes live is the most expensive way to set a room, as well as the most likely way to start a conference with a technical problem. Build that time into the RFP and the contract, not into your hopes for the week.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

Get your AV partner into the site selection conversation while you still have two buildings to choose between. That is the moment their read is worth the most to you, and it is the last moment it costs you nothing to act on.

PRO TIP

Production companies are on the road constantly. Ask your production manager whether they are already heading to a city you are considering. If it requires no additional travel, most will happily walk the venue and give you an honest read at no charge.

STAGE TWO

Planning

The venue is contracted. Every room is on 24-hour hold, you have the space the day before, and you know the building's rules. Now the work is sequencing, and **your schedule is what sets your crew size.**

- **Schedule the final site visit.** Three to six months out, walk the building with your event manager and your AV production manager. Ask who is in the space immediately before and immediately after you, and confirm their load-out does not collide with your load-in.
- **Agree on a production schedule at the kickoff.** This one document drives the whole planning process: when the presentation template goes out, when keynote decks are due, when rehearsals happen, when each room has to be ready. If it exists and people follow it, most of the onsite drama never happens.
- **Set a call cadence.** Monthly or bi-weekly far out, weekly as you get close. Match the frequency to the complexity of the program and the progress you are making, not to the calendar.
- **Put rehearsals on the schedule and tell your presenters.** A rehearsal everyone treats as optional is not a rehearsal.

- **Understand the meal break rules.** Crews generally need a break after four to five hours or penalties apply: a full hour off the clock and away from the workstation, or thirty minutes on the clock if you provide the meal. The first looks cheaper but costs momentum, especially on set day. Feeding the crew is usually the better trade, and it buys goodwill you will want at 11pm.
- **Ask about contingencies.** What happens if the internet goes down? Is the recording redundant? Is there spare gear onsite for the pop-up meeting that always appears? Name the components your conference cannot survive losing and confirm there is a plan for each one.
- **Collect technical riders.** Presenters and entertainers arrive with expectations about lighting, microphones, dressing rooms, and meals. Ask every one of them for their rider and forward it to your production manager as it arrives, not the week of the show.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

Your agenda is a budget document. A general session that ends at 5:00 and a reception that starts at 6:00 in the same room is a labor decision disguised as an agenda. Send the draft schedule to your production company early and ask what it is costing you.

PRO TIP

Music sets the tone of a meeting and can amplify your message. Choose it deliberately rather than at load-in, and then share the playlist with attendees after the event. It costs nothing and people remember it.

STAGE THREE

Execution

It's showtime. If planning went well, most of your job onsite is confirmation rather than correction. Check in with your AV team anyway, because there is one thing they need that only you have.

Your AV team does not carry the leverage with the venue that you do. When an airwall needs to open, a riser needs to appear, or power needs to be turned on, that request from you moves in minutes. The same request from a technician can take an hour.

- **Hold a standing end-of-day meeting.** Ten minutes with your AV team to trade notes, confirm tomorrow's changes, and surface anything still unresolved.
- **Confirm the crew is getting their breaks.** The plan you built in planning only helps if it is actually happening in the room.

- **Track additions as they happen.** Every added microphone, extended day, and pop-up meeting lands on the final invoice. Stay current with your production manager and there are no surprises in the reconciliation.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

Spend your leverage on your AV team. It is free to you, and it is the fastest tool available to them.

PRO TIP

Walk the rooms with your production manager. It catches problems, and more importantly it communicates exactly what "ready" means to you. Do it once on the first morning and the standard tends to hold all week.

STAGE FOUR

Review

The event was a success. Everyone is tired, the stakeholders are happy, and the natural thing to do is move on. Don't. **This is the cheapest hour you will spend on next year's event.**

- **Debrief within thirty days.** Sooner is better. Memory fades quickly, and specific feedback is worth far more than general feedback.
- **Trade notes in both directions.** Give the AV team yours, then give them room to share theirs. They watched your show from a different seat than you did.
- **Bring the outside feedback in.** Attendee, sponsor, and exhibitor comments belong in this conversation. A surprising amount of what they reacted to was a production decision.
- **Run it from positivity.** The purpose is not to assign blame, it is to make next year better. A debrief that feels like a trial produces nothing useful.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

The debrief is also a negotiation. Book next year while the event is fresh and the relationship is warm, and you will get a better number than you will in six months.

PRO TIP

Ask what a two or three year agreement changes. Rate protection, complimentary items, and priority on your dates are all easier to get before the market tightens around your dates.

What to do with this

None of this is complicated, really. It is important to take head on and early. Every item in this guide gets decided eventually, and the difference between deciding it in month two and discovering it in month ten is measured in dollars, and in how the room feels on show day.

Five questions to ask before you sign a venue contract

Ask the venue. Then have your AV partner read the answers.

- 1 Which spaces, if any, are exclusive to the in-house AV or rigging vendor?
- 2 If I bring in an outside AV partner, what will it cost me in fees, all in?
- 3 When do I take possession of each room, and is it on a 24-hour hold?
- 4 What does load-in look like from the dock to the meeting space?
- 5 Do these capacity numbers account for staging, screens, and front of house?

Any venue worth booking will answer all five. Keep the answers: they are the first half of your AV request for proposal.

You don't have to run all of it yourself. That is why I started Your AV Department.

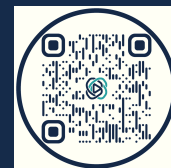
We would rather be in the room early.

Your AV Department works with planners across the whole lifecycle, from reading a venue contract to running the debrief, not just the weeks when the gear is on a truck. If you want a technical read on a building or a schedule before you commit, send it over.



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